

behaviour of all Dialog widgets—that is, to return some value(s). We can change this behaviour using the `--stdout` option, which is demonstrated in the next section where we use Dialog widgets in shell scripts.

We can also specify the starting locations of Dialog widgets and turn off the widget shadow. Enter the following command to see this in action:

```
dialog --no-shadow --begin 4 4 \
--backtitle "Input Box" --title inputbox --inputbox \
"Please enter something you like" 0 0 "FLOSS rule..."
```

If you check Figure 5, you'll notice that the inputbox widget is drawn at the top-left corner of the screen, rather than in the centre. This is the property of the `--begin` option. Also, the shadow has dissipated because of the `--no-shadow` common option. The inputbox widget shows a default string we provided on the Dialog command line, but we can change this string using the Delete or Backspace key and enter our desired input.

Till now, we have entered all the Dialog commands on the text console, but there is also an option to read Dialog parameters from a given file. Using the `--file` common option, we can put our commands in dialog `--file paramfile` form, where *paramfile* contains other Dialog parameters. This way we can control our widgets through their respective parameter files only.

We can also chain various Dialog widgets using the `--and-widget` option. Type the following command to see this process in action. Check Figure 6 for the output.

```
dialog --backtitle "Multiple dialog widgets" \
--begin 4 4 --title msgbox1 --msgbox First 0 0 \
--and-widget --begin 10 10 --title msgbox2 --msgbox Second 0 0 \
--and-widget --begin 16 16 --title msgbox3 --msgbox Third 0 0 \
--and-widget --begin 20 40 --title infobox1 \
--infobox "There are multiple widgets." 0 0 \
--and-widget --begin 30 35 --title infobox2 --infobox "I'm here too." 0 0
```

By now you must have a fair idea about some of the Dialog widgets and how to tweak their default behaviour using various options.

Dialog with shell scripts

To incorporate Dialog widgets in new or existing shell scripts we need to put the Dialog commands in the scripts along with two other considerations:

1. The value a widget returns to further process the script, if any; and/or,
2. The return status of the Dialog command to see what keyboard or mouse action the user has performed on the widget.

Use the `--stdout` option in the Dialog command line to obtain the value returned by a widget. To determine the kind of action taken on a widget, we have to examine the 'builtin shell variable `?`' that returns the exit status of the



Figure 4: Calendar widget with an extra button

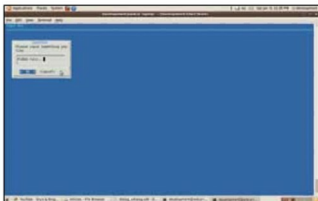


Figure 5: inputbox widget with the `--begin` and `--no-shadow` options

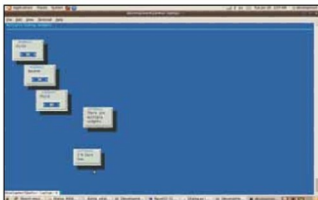


Figure 6: Multiple Dialog widgets

previous command.

The following shell script combines these concepts with some other Dialog widgets we haven't tried out yet. This shell script presents a menu with various options to select, and according to the options selected, information is displayed. Execute this shell script to see this feature in action.

```
#!/usr/bin/perl bash
```

```
# variables to hold command and common options.
```

```
dig=dialog
stdo=-stdout
title--title
```